Nehru saw his and the Congress's allies, in alignment with Gandhi, in the 'dumb semi-starved millions scattered over the length and breadth of the land'.[16] This economic framing of his political constituency stood at odds with the separate electorates that the British had introduced through the Indian Council Act, 1909, which grouped voters according to religious affiliations. Nehru thought that universal franchise would immediately end British rule. It would also 'give effect to the economic urges of the masses'.[17]

In Nehru's view, the Hindu-Muslim problem or communalism was at its core a problem of 'upper middle-class people' who only made up a small fraction of the Indian population. If the 'mass elements take part in the election of the constituent assembly', communal issues would 'recede into the background'.[18] Broadly secular in his political outlook, Nehru never warmed to the idea that religion deserved a place in progressive politics. 'The so-called Hindu-Muslim problem,' Nehru disclosed his position in usual frankness, 'is not a genuine problem concerning the masses, but it is the creation of self-seekers, job-hunters, and timid people, who believe in British rule in India till eternity.'[19]

For Nehru, therefore, it was telling that Muslim politicians preferred to discuss the communal question from a numerical perspective and connect it to reserved seats in the legislature or the colonial administration. Nehru openly raged against the Communal Award of 1932, the chief institution that the British had established to ensure the retention of separate electorates for Indian Muslims. At its core, Nehru saw reservations opposed to the egalitarian principles of nationalism.[20] 'It is absurd to consider this question [of communalism] from the point of view of numbers,' Nehru declared in the presence of Jinnah. 'If there was a question of numbers we thirty five crores [350 million] of people would not have become a slave country […] being dominated by a small number of people in Britain.'[21]